

BERGEN COUNTY/PASSAIC COUNTY, NEW JERSEY

THE RECORD, THURSDAY, MARCH 30, 1978

C-15

By Randolph Linthorst

On Nov. 12, 1931, 64-year-old Col. Jacob Ruppert, one of the country's richest men and owner of the New York Yankees, purchased the Newark Bears International League franchise.

Over the next seven years, the best young baseball talent ever assembled would perform in Newark, finishing five times, win over 100 games during four of those campaigns, and twice play in thrilling Junior World Series.

Charlie Keller, Red Rolfe, Spud Chandler, Joe Gordon, and dozens of other future stars would polish their skills in Newark. The Bears had so much talent that they were considered superior to many of the major league clubs of the day.

The Bears played their home games in Ruppert Stadium, a 30,000-seat structure built in 1926 and located in the middlelands on Wilson Avenue. The park was a pull litter's delight, but was tough on the straightaway batters. The fences at the home were 300 feet, and the bleachers were in front of the fence, so it was about 380 feet down the line.

Ally Demall, a great Bear pitcher in 1937 and 1938, recalls that "after looking at the short left and right-field foul lines, a pitcher had to make the batters hit straightaway or be in real trouble."

"Ruppert Stadium was a good batter's park at times, but could be tough, especially on left-handed batters," recalls first baseman George McQuinn, who played in Newark during the 1938 and 1937 campaigns. "The wind blew in a lot from right field. In 1938, I never seemed to get up."

Newark was like most of the other cities in the league—Jersey City, Buffalo, Baltimore, Reading, and several others—in the 1930s. Unemployment nearly reached six figures. There were rows of empty factories and free soup kitchens. Sometimes, people found the money to go to the ball game. In 1937, the Bears drew 30,000 at home, and over a seven-year

span played before almost one and a half million spectators.

If you couldn't attend a Bears game, or if they were away, you could listen to the dramatic play-by-play reporting of Earl Harper on radio. Harper broadcast the Newark games over a New York City station, WNYC. The three major-league clubs in New York—the Yankees, Giants, and Dodgers—had an agreement that, in effect, prohibited the regular broadcasting of games because the owners thought it would detract from the gate. Thousands of New Yorkers, with no broadcasts of local games, tuned in faithfully to Harper and the Bears.

Harper made "live" broadcasts of games played in Ruppert Stadium, but away contests were recreated back in the studio from telegraphic reports. During the simulated broadcasts, Harper would tap the microphone to make the sound of a bat crack.

"Earl had a bad limp due to a deformed hip," recalls a former Bear, Joe Beggs. "He was a highly excitable Bear fan, so much so that Jersey City wanted to keep him out of its ball park. He was loved by all the players."

"Harper was a great hype for the fans, particularly women," says Larry Keefe, a former sportswriter who is now sports information director at Seton Hall. "He was not a real student of the game and he exaggerated. I remember listening to a game at Buffalo and counted 10 spectacular plays. I later asked the late Mike Gaven, who covered the team for the Newark Star Eagle, how many outstanding plays there were. He said just one. The fans loved Harper's broadcasts, however, and he had a bad following."

The Bears won a pennant in Ruppert's first year, 1937, and went on to play the American Association champion Minneapolis Millers in the Junior World Series for the championship of the minor leagues. The fifth game, in bone-chilling weather at Hockett Park in Minneapolis, turned out to be one of the weirdest in the history of baseball.

The teams had each won two games, and the score of this one was 3 to 2 after six innings. In the bottom of the sixth, however, Minneapolis tallied five times to take an 8-3 lead. The Bears bounced back with two runs in the seventh and three in the eighth to tie it again, 8-8.

With one out in the Bears' half of the ninth, Jack Saltzgaver walked and went to third on Charlie Harper's single. Relief pitcher Johnny Murphy struck out, but then Johnny Neun lashed a drive to center. Harry Rice came up with the ball.

The third-base umpire flipped his hand in the air, indicating Neun was out. Al Manauza, the Bears' manager, heatedly protested that Rice had trapped the ball after it bounced, not caught it on the fly. The umpire finally admitted that he was in doubt, and conferred with the second-base umpire. The decision was changed in the Bears' favor. Now the Millers' manager, Donie Bush, stormed out of the dugout and argued. The decision was changed again, and Neun was out.

The umpires changed their minds three more times before ruling that Rice had trapped the ball, so Saltzgaver had scored on Neun's hit to give the Bears a 9-8 lead. Then, when play was finally resumed, Red Rolfe stepped to the plate and hit a three-run homer. The Millers added one run in the last of the ninth, but it was too little, too late.

Minneapolis protested the game, and a meeting was held the same night. The umpires, however, must have been established to settle any dispute before the series began. Thomas J. Hickey, president of the American Association, voted to allow the protest. William J. Mueley, secretary of the International League, voted against the protest. The third member of the Interstate League, voted against the protest. The third member of the Interstate League, voted against the protest. The third member of the Interstate League, voted against the protest.

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Baseball's great Newark Bears



An all-electric dwelling can be a dream house

Editor, The Record:

I read with interest Ron Sigmond's article "All-electric dream house can be nightmare to sell" in The Record, (Jan. 10).

Nine years ago I built an all-electric home, and although I did not do the actual construction, I did consider other heating options, for I had previously owned two oil-heated homes. I considered that as long as I needed electric for all other utilities, except heating and cooking, I would use one source, namely electric, rather than two or three. I also considered the possibility that the government might one day condemn systems with separate gas- or oil-burning systems on the basis of air pollution.

My nine years' experience in my all-electric home contradicts your article in respect to costs of an all-electric system. My home is a two-story colonial frame construction, situated on a two-acre lot, with no protection from ever winds and no shade trees. The house

has more than 2,000 square feet of living space and consists of eight rooms, three baths, two-car garage, and full basement. Every room has separate heating controls, including the baths, garage, hallways, and cellar. In all, we have separate heating controls at 17 locations. Each of our four bedrooms is insulated on ceiling, floor, and four walls, permitting us to close the door of each bedroom and separately control the heat of each room. If a bedroom is not used, we cut the heat in that room to 55 degrees. The home also has central air-conditioning with two separate systems, one for all of the upstairs and a separate system for downstairs. Our other electric appliances consist of electric stove top and oven, a 2.8 cubic foot no-frost refrigerator, 11.6 cubic foot freezer, electric water heater, well pump, and the other general household appliances. We also have two outside lamp posts and two spotlights that burn every night for four to six hours.

Our total electric bill for all of the above has averaged \$92 per year for the last three years. I would like someone to show me any comparable home with gas or oil heat, and with the utilities for cooking, air conditioning, lighting, etc., that can equal or do better than mine in my all-electric home.

I dispute the remarks of the builders quoted in your article regarding the all-electric home. Most builders do not build homes that are well insulated and tight enough to prevent air leakage. They think only of how cheaply they can build their speculation homes to make big profits. The least costly item in build-

ing a home is insulation. If insulation is of a good heavy thickness and properly installed, it can lower the heating and cooling costs on all homes, whether heated by gas, or electricity. Of great importance are good-quality windows with double- or triple-thick (thermo-pane) glass panes. All windows in my home are thermopane, however, most builders use cheap windows with single-pane glass. Poor installation and construction of windows cause air leakage and heat loss.

Dr. Freedman was quoted at the end of the article as saying: "People who get all-electric homes suffer alone." He should have said that people who buy cheap and poorly constructed homes suffer alone. I am very happy with my all-electric home and would build another if I were in the market for another house.

GIL ROBINSON
Ramey